Class 9: Can You Trust It, and Does Anyone Need It?

In class: the summary and the six rules for an honest judge, Deliverables 1 and 2, then 10 minutes each to start Deliverable 3 (round 1) and Deliverable 4 (signal table and survey).

Homework: finish Deliverables 3 and 4 (including your five Class 2 interviews if you have not done them yet), do Deliverable 5, put everything in one PDF (Deliverable 6) and upload it by Sunday 15 November, 23:59. Late uploads are still accepted, with a 10% grade reduction.

Part 1. Summary

Where you are. This course follows one venture from an idea to Demo Day. Each class added one piece. Today you test the two big guesses that every investor will ask about on 24 November: does your product work reliably, and does anyone need it?

Class	What you did	What it gave your venture
Classes 1 and 2	Picked a problem, wrote a testable hypothesis, interviewed people who have the problem	A problem, and the people who have it
Class 3	Drew the line between what you own and what AI does (Co-Founder Charter); wrote three big guesses: desirable, feasible, viable	The guesses you still have to prove
Classes 4 and 5	Built a first version; learned that code is now cheap and “you cannot defend a product that nobody wants”	A product, and a reason to prove demand
Class 6	Shipped one working feature at the midterm	A product that works
Class 7	Designed a learning loop with a human safety check, chose growth metrics (for example “the AI is right 80% of the time, not 50%”), named your Red Line	A promise: the product gets better over time
Class 8	Ran 15 test cases, marked each answer OK or not OK, counted errors per step, fixed one step	A sheet of 15 answers you judged yourself
Class 9 (today)	Teach an AI to judge the way you did; ask your users if they would miss you	Numbers for two of your Class 3 guesses: feasible (does it work?) and desirable (do people need it?)
Classes 10 and 11	Pitch prep, rehearsal, Demo Day	The story, backed by today’s numbers

The Main Idea: Last week you read 15 answers and decided yourself which were OK. That was the human safety check from Class 7. It works for 15 cases. It does not work when your product answers hundreds of requests a week, and in Class 7 you promised to show that your product is getting better. You cannot show that without measuring it again and again.

So today you write down how you judged, give those rules to an AI (a judge), and check that the judge agrees with you. Once it does, it can check every new answer for you, so you can show week by week whether your product is getting better. This is also what makes a venture AI-native: a core job inside the company, here checking quality, is done by AI first, with a human who sets the standard and checks the AI. It is your Co-Founder Charter from Class 3 applied to quality: you own the judgement, the AI applies it.

Then you test the other big guess. A product that works only matters if people need it, so you ask your users the product-market fit question, with a number this time. In Class 2 some interviews ended with “I would use it”; today you find out how many would be very disappointed without it.

Pre-reads for this class: Hamel Husain, “Using LLM-as-a-Judge For Evaluation” (how to write and check a judge prompt); Anthropic, “Demystifying Evals for AI Agents” (code, AI and human graders); Spotify Engineering, “Better Experiments with LLM Evals” (an eval is not the same as what users do); Chip Huyen, AI Engineering (tie evaluation metrics to business metrics); Rahul Vohra, “How Superhuman Built an Engine to Find Product-Market Fit” (ask users how they would feel if they could no longer use the product); Bessemer, “Mastering Product-Market Fit: A Detailed Playbook for AI Founders” (PMF as a spectrum); Anthropic, The Founder’s Playbook (PMF measurement and false positives).

The case in today’s pre-read: Honeycomb. Honeycomb is a company that sells software engineers a tool to find out why their apps are slow or broken, by searching their system data with queries. Its Query Assistant lets an engineer type a question in plain English (“what is the slowest trace?”) and the AI writes the query. Hamel helped Honeycomb build an AI judge for those queries. One expert, Phillip Carter, first marked each query pass or fail and wrote why. Those notes went into the judge prompt, and after three rounds of changes the judge agreed with Phillip more than 90% of the time.

Four things to learn today:

- **A judge is your own judgement, written down.** It is a prompt that asks an AI to mark an answer PASS or FAIL with a reason. It learns your standard from the reasons you write.

- **Check the judge before you trust it.** Count how often it agrees with you, separately for failures and for passes. Hamel warns that one overall agreement number can hide a judge that never catches a failure.
- **A better score is not yet a better business.** Spotify checks its judges against what real users then do. Chip Huyen advises linking each eval number to a business number.
- **Product-market fit is measured, not felt.** Ask users: “How would you feel if you could no longer use the product?” If 40% or more say “very disappointed”, you are close to product-market fit (Superhuman). Then say honestly where you are on the scale (Bessemer), and watch for signals that look good but are not real.

Part 2. Six Rules for Keeping an AI Judge Honest

These rules come from the pre-reads and from the Reforge AI Evals course. Keep them in mind while you build and check your judge in Deliverables 1 to 3.

- **The judge is there to make you read your answers, not to replace reading them.** Hamel calls building a judge “a nice ‘hack’ I use to trick people into carefully looking at their data”. The Reforge course says a person should read at least ten answers before writing any rule. (Hamel, p 16; Reforge course toolkit)
- **One expert on your user decides what a good answer is.** Pick the person on your team who knows best what a good answer looks like for your user. If that is only a founder’s opinion, check it against real users. (Hamel, p 3)
- **Check the judge against your own PASS and FAIL before you trust it.** “LLM-as-judge graders should be closely calibrated with human experts.” Once the judge is reliable, “human review only occasionally” is enough. (Anthropic, p 4)
- **Keep reading answers yourself, and check again after any change.** Anthropic: “we regularly take the time to read them.” Hamel: the process “repeats periodically or when material changes occur”, such as a new model, prompt or feature. (Anthropic, p 4; Hamel, p 16)
- **Check the judge against what users actually do.** Judges “can drift”, and “without offline-online signal calibration, our evals are opinions, not evidence.” (Spotify, p 3)
- **Not every failure needs a judge.** First ask whether your product was ever told to handle the case. If it was not, fix the prompt. If it never works, change the design. Only a failure that happens some of the time needs an eval, and a plain code check comes before an AI judge. (Reforge course toolkit)

How often, for your team: re-run your 15 cases after every change to the prompt, the model or a feature, and read 10 real answers yourself every week until Demo Day. This is our rule of thumb; the pre-reads give no fixed number.

Deliverable 1. Write Down How You Judged (In class)

You already have: your Class 8 sheet, where you marked each of the 15 answers OK or not OK.

The next step: write down why. A judge can only copy your judgement if your reasons are on paper. Pick one person on the team to do this: the one who knows best what a good answer looks like for your user (Hamel: one main expert keeps the judging consistent).

For each of the 15 cases, add two columns to your Class 8 sheet:

- **PASS or FAIL:** your OK becomes PASS, your not OK becomes FAIL. No 1 to 5 scores: Hamel says people read such scales differently, while a yes or no forces you to decide what matters.
- **Why:** one or two sentences, so a new team member could judge the next case the same way. “Bad answer” is not a reason; “milk and eggs became one item with no amount” is.

Check what the product did, not only what it said (the planter case from Class 8): if your app should save, send or book something, look at whether it did.

Then write your rules. Read your reasons again. What did you check every time? Write 3 to 5 rules a good answer must meet, and add your Red Line from Class 7 as the thing it must never do.

Examples from ventures in this class (examples only, not the teams’ real rules):

- **Daily Hello:** turn amber or red when the parent mentions a fall, pain or confusion, even if the parent asks not to tell; never invent symptoms the parent did not mention; fit in three lines.
- **Nutritrack:** every item on the receipt appears once, with an amount; discount lines are not products; if the photo is not a receipt, say so instead of guessing.

If your rules changed while you wrote them, that is normal. Hamel calls it criteria drift: you find out what you care about by judging. Go back and check the first cases against the final rules.

Deliverable 2. Give Your Rules to an AI Judge (In class)

You already have: your rules and 15 judged cases from Deliverable 1.

The next step: turn them into a prompt. First take out any rule a simple check can do without AI (Anthropic): for example “the answer is under 500 characters” or “the app called the refund tool”. The AI judge is for rules that need reading: is the summary correct, was a risk missed, is the tone right.

The prompt (fill in the brackets, then copy it into a chat AI such as ChatGPT or Claude, and save it as judgeprompt.md):

You are checking the answers of [product], which [who the user is and the job the app does for them, in one sentence].

A good answer must: 1. [rule] 2. [rule] 3. [rule]. It must never: [your Red Line].

Here are answers our team already judged. Request: [case]. Answer: [what the app said and did]. Verdict: [PASS or FAIL]. Why: [your reason]. [Add 2 more cases from your sheet. Include at least one FAIL.]

Now judge the case below. First write your reason in one or two sentences. Then, on the last line, write only PASS, FAIL or UNKNOWN. Write UNKNOWN if the information is not enough to decide.

Request: [case]. Answer: [what the app said and did].

Why it is written this way: your own judged cases teach the judge your standard (Hamel); the reason comes before the verdict, so the judge explains before it decides; UNKNOWN stops the judge from guessing (Anthropic).

Deliverable 3. Does the Judge Agree With You? (10 minutes in class, finish at home)

You already have: a judge prompt, and your own verdict on every case.

The next step: test the judge the way you tested your product in Class 8. The 3 cases you put in the prompt do not count, so run the judge on the other 12, one at a time, and write its verdict next to yours. In class you have 10 minutes: run round 1 on as many cases as you can, and finish the rest at home.

Case	Our verdict	Judge, round 1	Judge, round 2	Judge, round 3	What we changed in the prompt
4					
5					

...					
15					

Count two things, not one (Hamel):

- **Failures caught:** of the cases you marked FAIL, how many did the judge also mark FAIL? ___ of ___
- **Passes agreed:** of the cases you marked PASS, how many did the judge also mark PASS? ___ of ___

Example (Nutritrack, made up to show the method, not the team's real results): the team marked 7 of 12 cases FAIL. In round 1 the judge caught 4 of the 7 failures and agreed on all 5 passes. Its reasons showed it never looked for merged items, because no rule said each receipt line must appear once. The team added that rule and one FAIL example; in round 2 the judge caught 6 of 7.

If a number is low, read the judge's reasons where it was wrong, change one thing in the prompt, and run again. Stop after three rounds. Keep every version of the prompt.

Now use it on your Class 7 promise. Look at the growth metric you chose in Class 7. If the judge can measure it (for example "the AI is right 80% of the time"), write today's number: this is your starting point, and you measure again before Demo Day. If it needs real users (for example how many stories users finish), the judge cannot measure it. Say what you would need to measure it.

- Our Class 7 metric: ___ Can the judge measure it? ___ If yes, today's number: ___%
- Would you trust this judge to check your product every week? Why or why not?

Deliverable 4. Ask Your Users if They Would Miss You (10 minutes in class, finish at home)

You already have: the people you interviewed in Class 2 and the users who tried your product since the midterm.

The next step: a judge tells you whether the product does what you intended. Only users tell you whether it matters (Spotify). Demo Day is on 24 November, and the first question will be whether anyone needs your product.

Do not expect to be there yet. Lenny Rachitsky looked at 24 of today's top B2B startups. Most had a first working product within 1 to 3 months, but it took them a median of about 2 years from the first idea to feel product-market fit, and Figma, Airtable and Slack took more than 4 years.

Your job by Demo Day is to measure honestly how close you are. (Lenny's Newsletter, 12 September 2023)

Step 1. Where are you today? (In class) Bessemer describes product-market fit as a scale, not a yes or no:

- **Light signal:** a handful of early users love the product, but they do not come back reliably.
- **Moderate signal:** one group of users shows strong use or early revenue.
- **Strong signal:** users stay, tell others, and pull the product faster than you can deliver.

Signal	Our evidence today (numbers, names, dates)	Could it be a false positive? Why?
Users who came back a second time		
Users who would pay, or already pay		
Users who told someone else		
Our place on the scale: light, moderate or strong		

False positives to watch for (The Founder's Playbook): signups without real use, revenue without retention, and early excitement without repeat use. Bessemer warns that in AI, very fast early traction does not always turn into lasting revenue.

Step 2. Send the survey before you leave the room (In class). Use a Google Form or Typeform. Send it to everyone who has used your product, starting with your Class 2 interviewees. Vohra asked only people who had used the product at least twice in the last two weeks; mark the others separately.

1. How would you feel if you could no longer use [product]? (Very disappointed / Somewhat disappointed / Not disappointed)

2. What type of people do you think would most benefit from [product]?

3. What is the main benefit you receive from [product]?

4. How can we improve [product] for you?

Missing your Class 2 interviews? Do them now (Homework). If your team did not talk to five people who have the problem in Class 2, do it by Sunday 15 November. Same rules as in Class 2: people in your target group, not friends or family where you can avoid it, and no leading questions (ask what they do today, not whether they like your idea). Then show them your

product and send them the survey. For each interview, write the date, who it was (role, not name) and one sentence in their own words.

Step 3. Report honestly (Homework):

- Number of answers: ___ (Vohra: results start to give a direction at around 40 answers; with fewer, say so)
- % very disappointed: ___ (40% or more is the Sean Ellis benchmark; Superhuman started at 22%)
- Who answered: real users, or classmates and friends? Mark them separately.
- The main benefit in your users' own words (question 3), and the top request (question 4).
- Look only at the users who would be very disappointed. Who are they? That is the user your Demo Day pitch should be about.

Deliverable 5. AI Grader (Homework)

Run the AI grader on your Deliverables 1 to 4, and ask one classmate to score them too. You built a judge yourself today, so look at this grader with the same eyes: where would you disagree with it?

Grading Categories (from 1 to 5, used by both classmates and AI)

- **Clear rules:** Does every case have a verdict and a reason, and are the rules clear enough that someone else could judge the same way?
- **Checked judge:** Does the team show failures caught and passes agreed, and improve the prompt over rounds?
- **Honest about users:** Is the PMF evidence real, with the number of answers and who answered?

The Prompt for the AI Grader

(Copy this text into a chat AI such as ChatGPT or Claude)

You are a strict reviewer of an early-stage AI product. Score the following work on three categories, from 1 to 5. Do not reward a perfect-looking result: a judge that agrees 100% on easy cases is worth less than one tested on real failures, and a survey with 5 honest answers is worth more than an inflated one.

Category 1, Clear rules: 1 means verdicts without reasons, 5 means every case has a clear reason and the rules could be used by someone else.

Category 2, Checked judge: 1 means the judge was not compared with the team's verdicts, 5 means failures caught and passes agreed are counted separately and the prompt improved over rounds.

Category 3, Honest about users: 1 means no user evidence, 5 means the survey and signals are reported with the number of answers and who answered, including weak results.

Give a score and one sentence explaining why for each category. Then name one rule this team's judge is missing. Here is the student work: [paste Deliverables 1 to 4].

Compare

- AI Score:
- Classmate Score:
- Why the scores were different (one sentence):

Deliverable 6. Summary Document (Homework)

Upload one zip file to the Session 9 Submission Area on eCampus by Sunday 15 November, 23:59. Late uploads are still accepted, with a 10% grade reduction. The zip contains one PDF, your judge prompt (judgeprompt.md, all versions), your Class 8 sheet with the new columns (.xlsx or .csv), and your updated architecturedoc.md.

The PDF contains:

A. Your Rules: the 3 to 5 rules and your Red Line, and the 15 verdicts with reasons (from Deliverable 1).

B. Judge Prompt: the final version (from Deliverable 2).

C. Judge Check: failures caught and passes agreed for each round, the judge's biggest mistake, and, if the judge can measure it, your Class 7 metric today (from Deliverable 3).

D. Users: your signal table and place on the scale; the survey results: number of answers, % very disappointed, who answered, main benefit and top request; and, if you did them this week, your five interviews with dates (from Deliverable 4).

E. AI Grader: the AI score, the classmate score, and why they differ (from Deliverable 5).

F. A link to your MVP.